

The Noble Great Vehicle Dhāraṇī Sūtra of the Casket of the Secret Relics, the Heart of the Blessing of All the Tathāgatas

Ārya-sarva-tathāgata-adhiṣṭhāna-hṛdaya-guhya-dhātu-karaṇḍa-nāma-dhāraṇī-mahāyāna-sūtra · Toh 507 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་དྲེའུ་གཤེས་པ་བྲམས་ཅད་

Toh 507 in the Kangyur is a Mahāyāna dhāraṇī sūtra known in English as "The Great Vehicle Dhāraṇī Sūtra of the Noble Casket of the Secret Relics, the Heart of the Blessing of All the Tathāgatas," in Sanskrit as the Ārya-sarva-tathāgata-adhiṣṭhāna-hṛdaya-guhya-dhātu-karaṇḍa-nāma-dhāraṇī-mahāyāna-sūtra, and in Tibetan as Phags pa de bzhin gshegs pa thams cad kyi byin gyi rlabs kyi snying po gsang ba'i ring bsrel za ma tog ces bya ba theg pa chen po'i mdo. The text belongs to the dhāraṇī sūtra genre, presenting sacred syllables and ritual instructions centered on the power of the relics and blessings of all the tathāgatas — a subject with strong connections to stūpa veneration and the consecration of reliquary objects. The sūtra opens with the Buddha residing in Magadha, surrounded by a vast assembly of bodhisattvas, śrāvakas, and an array of divine and semi-divine beings, establishing the classic setting for the revelation of a teaching of far-reaching spiritual efficacy.

In the language of India: Ārya-sarva-tathāgata-adhiṣṭhāna-hṛdaya-guhya-dhātu-karaṇḍa-nāma-dhāraṇī-mahāyāna-sūtra.

In the language of Tibet: The Great Vehicle Dhāraṇī Sūtra of the Noble Casket of the Secret Relics, the Heart of the Blessing of All the Tathāgatas.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling in the land of Magadha, in the immaculate pleasure grove, in a pool of seven kinds of precious gems, together with a great assembly of bodhisattvas, a great assembly of śrāvakas, and many tens of thousands of gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, great mahoragas, humans, and non-humans, surrounded and attended by many hundreds of thousands of people of that land, all gathered before him.

Now in that assembly there was a great brahmin, wise as a great śāla tree, learned, clear-minded, inwardly settled, pleasant to behold, and fully committed to the tenfold path of virtuous action. His name was Vimalasudrśa

— Spotless Goodly Appearance. He was singularly endowed with virtuous intention, faithfully venerating the Three Jewels with heartfelt devotion. He was a careful examiner, diligently serving the welfare of all sentient beings and of virtue. He was a man of great wealth, great resources, great prosperity, abundant possessions, and fully equipped with all that he required.

Then the great brahmin Vimalasudṛśa went to where the Blessed One was, and having arrived, he circumambulated the Blessed One seven times, and offered him flowers and incense. He presented robes valued at a hundred thousand, and he also offered the Blessed One a garland of pearls valued at a hundred thousand. He then prostrated, touching his head to the Blessed One's two feet, and seated himself in the presence of the Blessed One, and addressed him thus: "Blessed One, together with the retinue of sons of the Victor, I invite you to my home for a meal — would the Blessed One please be gracious enough to grant this?"

Then the Blessed One, having understood in his heart the invitation of the great brahmin Vimalasudṛśa, said nothing in reply, and by his silence gave his consent.

Then the great brahmin Vimalasudṛśa, understanding from the Blessed One's silence before him that consent had been given, went home with leisurely and dignified steps. That very night he had food prepared — meals of a hundred flavors, in great abundance — and he arranged a magnificently adorned auspicious pavilion and various great pavilions, and taking flowers, incense, a great retinue, and musical instruments, and with cymbals resounding, he went to where the Blessed One was and announced to the Blessed One that the time had come.

Then the great brahmin Vimalasudṛśa addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, the time has come for your arrival. Blessed One, may it please you to come at the appointed hour."

Then the Blessed One, heartened by the great brahmin Vimalasudṛśa, looked upon his own retinue and declared: "All of you who have come here — today you will accomplish something of great importance. Come now."

Then the Blessed One rose from his seat, and immediately upon rising from his seat, many different rays of light shone forth from the body of the Blessed One. The radiance of those light rays illuminated all the buddha-fields in the ten directions, urging all the Tathāgatas to look on and to know that he was setting forth.

Then the great brahmin Vimalasudṛśa, with offerings and —

with great reverence made offerings and beautifully adorned the path the Blessed One had taken. The great assembled retinue — gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kiṃnaras, mahoragas, Śakra (Indra, king of the gods), Brahmā, the world-guardians, the Great Lord (Maheśvara), Nārāyaṇa, and the four great kings — also adorned that path beautifully.

Not far along the road from the Blessed One's position, there was a pleasure grove called Ānandakara. Within that grove stood an ancient great stūpa, crumbled and filled with thorns, overgrown with grass, trees, and weeds — like a heap of rags.

As the Blessed One approached it, that ancient stūpa, like a heap of rags, blazed forth from all sides with burning light rays of many colors. And from that heap of rags and weeds there arose a voice saying: "Excellent! Excellent, Tathāgata Śākyamuni! Today this is an auspicious omen of your coming. And you too, great brahmin who invited the Tathāgata — excellent! Today something of great importance will be done for you."

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, made obeisance to that ancient stūpa, that heap of rags, with five limbs touching the ground, circumambulated it three times, then removed his upper robe from his own body and spread it over that ancient stūpa, that heap of rags. The Blessed One brought forth great flowing tears and wiped them away, and then the Blessed One showed a smile. In showing that smile, he saw all the Tathāgatas of the ten directions as though present in the palm of his hand. All those Tathāgatas then released rays of light that entered into that great heap of the ancient stūpa.

Then the great assembled retinue who had gathered there were filled with wonder and settled into faith.

Then Vajrapāṇi, the great lord of yakṣas, his body trembling and his heart shaken, his vajra drawn tight and held firm, went to where the Blessed One was, and arriving there, bowed his head to the feet of the Blessed One and said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what is this great omen of wiping away tears, this omen displayed by showing the Blessed One's eyes filled with tears? Why did the Blessed One open this question before this assembly? Please explain."

Then the Blessed One spoke thus to Vajrapāṇi, the great lord of yakṣas: "Vajrapāṇi, there is a teaching called the Dharma category of the mudrā of the

dhāraṇī of the essence of all Tathāgatas — the stūpa of relics, the Tathāgata stūpa, containing as many Tathāgatas as there are sesame seeds in a hundred thousand ten-million sesame pods. Vajrapāṇi, wherever this Dharma category resides, there dwell as many as ten million times a hundred thousand Tathāgatas, and the bodily relics of as many Tathāgatas as can be numbered reside there. The eighty-four thousand collections of Dharma reside there. The uṣṇīṣas and crowns of as many as ninety-nine times ten million times a hundred thousand Tathāgatas reside there likewise. Vajrapāṇi, wherever this Dharma category resides, that place is prophesied as a Tathāgata stūpa. Vajrapāṇi, this Dharma category is of great benefit and great power. Vajrapāṇi, this Dharma category is of great benefit."

Vajrapāṇi, this Dharma category perfects all auspiciousness.

Then, upon hearing this Dharma category, the many members of the assembly gathered around the Blessed One obtained the dustless, stainless eye of Dharma with respect to phenomena, and became free from the proximate afflictions. Some attained the fruit of stream-entry. Some attained arhathood itself. Some attained the fruit of pratyekabuddha awakening. Some attained the fruit of non-return. Some attained the fruit of once-return. Some were established on the bodhisattva grounds. Some received a prophecy of awakening. Some reached the first ground. Some the second ground. Some the third. Some the fourth. Some the fifth. Some the sixth. Some the seventh. Some the eighth. Some the ninth. Some came to abide on the tenth ground. Some fully perfected the six perfections. That great brahmin as well attained the five superknowledges, became free from defilement, and was liberated from miserliness and envy.

Then the great lord of yakṣas Vajrapāṇi, having witnessed such a great miracle, was filled with immense wonder and amazement, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, if one who merely hears the name of this Dharma category attains such an adornment of qualities and benefits, what need is there to speak of one on whose behalf homage and very abundant veneration are performed? Blessed One, what a mass of merit such a person would behold!"

The Blessed One declared: "Vajrapāṇi, listen. Whoever among sons of good family or daughters of good family, among monks or nuns, among laymen or laywomen inquires about this Dharma category — Vajrapāṇi, such a person will come to possess a mass of merit and a generation of wholesome roots

equal to as many as ninety-nine times ten million times a hundred thousand sesame-seed-filled containers of Tathāgatas, and will be taken under the care of all those Tathāgatas. Those who recite it will likewise hold all the sūtra collections spoken by all Tathāgatas. Those who retain such a Dharma category as this will be held by ninety-nine times ten million times a hundred thousand Tathāgatas in each of the ten directions — that is, by the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas of each direction — and will be looked upon by them each and every day.

Sons of good family, daughters of good family, laymen, or laywomen who make offerings to this Dharma category, who internalize it, and who make offerings with flowers, incense, fragrance, garlands, unguents, garments, streamers, and ornaments — they will make offerings to ninety-nine times ten million times a hundred thousand Tathāgatas in each of the ten directions and in every single direction with divine flowers, incense, fragrance, garlands, unguents, garments, streamers, and ornaments. In each and every direction, for each Tathāgata, there will arise a cloud of offerings to the Tathāgata — a mass of qualities as great as a mighty Mount Meru fashioned from the seven precious substances.

Then the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas (gandharva), asuras, garuḍas (garuḍa), kinnaras (kinnara), great serpents (mahoraga), humans,

and non-humans, and all those great assemblies of sentient beings were filled with wonder, and said to one another: "This old stūpa, consecrated by heaps of dirty rags, by the blessing of the Tathāgata — this is a great display of miraculous power, mighty through the power of the Teacher."

Then Vajrapāṇi, the great yakṣa general, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, who has transformed these heaps of dirty rags into a precious stūpa?" The Blessed One declared: "Vajrapāṇi, this is not a heap of dirty rags. It is a great and precious stūpa fashioned from the seven precious substances. Vajrapāṇi, nevertheless, what appears as the karmic maturation of the ripening of beings' karma will come to ruin. But the stūpas that are the essence of the relics of the Tathāgatas of all the buddhas will not perish or scatter. How could the vajra-essence body of a Tathāgata ever scatter? Yet even that which appears as the karmic maturation of beings' karma will come to ruin.

"Vajrapāṇi, moreover, in a later age, at a later time, there will arise in great abundance those who commit every kind of evil, those who are steeped in evil,

and those who are destined for the deepest hells. They will not seek a buddha, will not seek the Dharma, will not seek the Saṅgha, and will not generate wholesome roots. It is through those causes and conditions that the sacred Dharma will decline. Vajrapāṇi, for this reason my two eyes are filled with tears, and likewise all Tathāgatas have shed tears. Such enumerations of the sacred Dharma will decline — except for the Tathāgata stūpa, which all Tathāgatas will bless.

Then Vajrapāṇi, the great yakṣa general, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what wholesome roots will arise for one who writes out this enumeration of the Dharma and places it inside a stūpa?" The Blessed One declared: "Vajrapāṇi, whoever writes out this enumeration of the Dharma and places it inside a stūpa — that stūpa will become the vajra-essence relic stūpa of all Tathāgatas. It will become a stūpa consecrated by the secret dhāraṇī-essence of all Tathāgatas. It will become as many stūpas as there are sesame seeds that could fill ninety-nine times ten million vessels. It will be consecrated as the crown-protrusion stūpa and the eye stūpa of all Tathāgatas. Whoever places a buddha image or any stūpa inside it — that image of the Tathāgata will be consecrated as being of the nature of the seven precious substances. Wheel-garlands, and nets strung with bells and ornaments, auspicious forms, parasol shapes, and bells — all these will be consecrated as being of the nature of the seven precious substances. Through the power, the blessing, the truth, and the sacred vow of all Tathāgatas and of this enumeration of the Dharma, it will be consecrated as far as the heart of awakening itself.

"Sentient beings who bow down before and circumambulate that stūpa will certainly become irreversible and will fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed complete awakening. By a single prostration or a single circumambulation, they will be completely liberated from the Avīci hell and all other such states, and will become irreversible from unsurpassed complete awakening."

The site where such a stūpa or image abides will likewise be consecrated by all Tathāgatas. In that place, hostile nāgas will have no power to cause harm. Hail and frost will have no power there. Hostile living creatures and venomous ones will have no power to cause harm in that place. Predatory beasts will have no power there. There will be no threat from inauspicious birds, crows, owls, mice, rats, flies, insects, ants, three-lipped mosquitoes, long-billed creatures, or horse-flies. Venomous serpents will have no power to cause harm there.

In that place, epidemic disease, contagious illness, and strife will not arise. There will be no threat from yakṣas, rākṣasas, spirits, hungry ghosts, demons, or the terror of oblivion-causing spirits. No malign spirits of any kind will have power there. No plague of any kind will have power there. All diseases — boils, eye ailments, goiter, nocturnal eruptions, dropsy, scabies, leprosy — will have no power, and by the mere sight of that stūpa, all such afflictions will be cleansed.

In that place, disease among cattle, disease among livestock, disease among animals of the many other forms of animal birth, and disease among men, women, boys, and girls will never gain a foothold. Untimely death will bring no untimely end there. Neither poison nor weapon, neither fire nor flood, will ever have power there. No fear from enemy armies will arise, and no fear from failed harvests will ever gain a foothold. The terror of the armies of great kings will not arise there.

The four great kings will perpetually and without interruption guard and fully protect that place. The twenty-eight great commanders of the yakṣa hosts will also perpetually and without interruption guard, protect, and shelter it. The twenty-eight lunar mansions, together with the moon, the sun, and the great planets, will move in harmony day and night. All the kings of the nāgas will perpetually and without cease send down streams of wholesome rain — rain that does not dim the luster of things and that is entirely beneficial.

All the gods will come from the thirty-two abodes at the three times of day to prostrate before, honor, and make offerings at that great stūpa. All who dwell in that region will likewise come at the three times to the presence of that stūpa and image, to praise and circumambulate them. Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), together with his divine daughters and all the divine hosts, will come perpetually and without interruption to the presence of that stūpa or image at the three times of day and night, to prostrate and make offerings. All Tathāgatas will perpetually turn their minds toward it and bestow their blessing upon it.

Whatever the stūpa or image is made of — whether earth, stone, wood, silver, gold, or copper — if this enumeration of the Dharma is written and placed inside it, at the very moment of its being placed within, it will be consecrated to the nature of the seven precious substances. The cornice, the steps, the frieze, the ring of wheel-ornaments, the auspicious emblems, the canopy, the hanging bells, the banners, and all the nets of tinkling bell-ornaments will

likewise become of the nature of the seven precious substances.

In all four directions, images of the Tathāgata will likewise come to be present. It will become a precious stūpa consecrated by the blessing of all the Tathāgatas, a stūpa that is the essence of bodily relics, and a place worthy of veneration. That image and that stūpa will be thoroughly protected and embraced with offerings even by the gods of the Akaniṣṭha realm.

Then the great yakṣa general Vajrapāṇi addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, how is it that this enumeration of the Dharma comes to possess such extraordinary qualities?"

The Blessed One declared: "It is because this is the dhāraṇī of the mudrā of the jeweled casket, the secret essence of relics, consecrated by all the Tathāgatas. Therefore, Vajrapāṇi, this power is consecrated by blessing with such extraordinary qualities."

Vajrapāṇi then asked: "Blessed One, would you be pleased to teach the enumeration of the Dharma of the dhāraṇī of the mudrā of the precious casket?"

The Blessed One declared: "Vajrapāṇi, listen well. The body of the Tathāgata of all buddhas, all Blessed Ones — those of the past, those yet to come, those of the present, and all those who have passed fully into nirvāṇa — is threefold: the dharmakāya, the saṃbhogakāya, and likewise the nirmāṇakāya. This is the enumeration of the Dharma of the dhāraṇī of the mudrā of the jeweled casket of relics of all three times.

Namaḥ straya dhīkānām. Sarva tathāgatānām. Oṃ bhū vi bhavān vare va caṭau. Culu culu. Dhara dhara. Sarva tathāgata. Dhātu dhare. Padmagarbhe. Jaya vare. Acale. Smara tathāgata. Dharma cakra. Pravartana. Vajra bodhi maṇḍa alaṃkāra. Alaṃkṛte. Sarva tathāgata. Adhiṣṭhite. Bodhaya bodhaya. Bodhanī bodhanī. Buddhya buddhya. Saṃbodhanī saṃbodhaya. Cala cala. Calantu sarva āvaraṇāni. Sarva pāpaṃ vigate. Huru huru. Sarva śoka vigate. Sarva tathāgata hṛdaya. Vajriṇī. Sambhava sambhava. Sarva tathāgata guhye. Ghāraṇī mudre. Buddhē. Subuddhē. Sarva tathāgata adhiṣṭhite. Dhātu garbhe svāhā. Samaya adhiṣṭhite svāhā. Sarva tathāgata hṛdaya. Dhātu mudre svāhā. Supraṭiṣṭhita stūpe tathāgata adhiṣṭhite. Hūṃ hūṃ svāhā. Oṃ sarva tathāgata uṣṇīṣa dhātu mudraṇi sarva tathāgata dharmadhātu vibhūṣita adhiṣṭhite huru huru. Hūṃ hūṃ svāhā."

No sooner had the Blessed One finished teaching this dhāraṇī of the mudrā of the jeweled casket of relics than, from all ten directions and from each individual direction, inconceivable hundreds of thousands of millions of Tathāgatas — as many as ninety-nine sesame seeds would fill a vessel — came forth. They said "Excellent! Excellent!" to the Blessed One Śākyamuni, praising Śākyamuni for having, for the sake of all sentient beings in Jambudvīpa, established such a treasury of Dharma in the form of this enumeration of Dharma, and for having consecrated the stūpa that is the essence of relics. "This is the pledge and the blessing of all the Tathāgatas."

Wherever someone teaches this dhāraṇī of the mudrā of relics, or places it inside a stūpa, or places it inside an image, the Tathāgatas will continuously and without interruption be present there together, following and abiding. In every place, it will be consecrated by the blessing of the Tathāgatas.

Then, along with the teaching of the dhāraṇī,

However decrepit a stūpa may have become, reduced to no more than a heap of crumbling plaster, it shall rise up and be exalted as a stūpa composed of the seven precious substances, perfectly arrayed with a finial, adorned with garlands of wheels, and endowed with every auspicious mark.

The Blessed One, delighted, having spoken thus, the bodhisattva and great being Vajrapāṇi, along with the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas (scent-eaters), garuḍas (sky-soaring divine eagles), kinnaras (half-human beings), and mahoragas (great serpent beings), together with the world of gods and humans, rejoiced at what the Blessed One had declared and praised it with acclaim.

The noble dhāraṇī called "The Basket of Secret Relics, the Essence of the Blessing of All the Tathāgatas," a sūtra of the Great Vehicle, is complete.

This was translated by the Indian scholar Vidyākaraṇa and

Translator's Notes

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end of the passage, so the translation ends accordingly.

The name Vimalasudṛśa is a back-reconstruction from the Tibetan Dri med legs snang, meaning "Spotless Goodly Appearance." The Sanskrit title given at the opening is transliterated directly from the Tibetan phonetic rendering of the Sanskrit and matches known versions of this dhāraṇī text.

The phrase rendered "wise as a great śāla tree" follows the Tibetan comparison to the great śāla tree, a standard Indian simile for a person of noble stature and steadiness, not merely physical size.

- The term translated as "mahoragas" renders རྒྱུ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་, literally "great belly-crawlers," the standard Tibetan for the Sanskrit mahoraga, great serpentine beings. "Ānandakara" is a back-rendered Sanskrit name for རྒྱུ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་, meaning "the pleasure grove that creates well-being." The epithet རྒྱུ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ is a Tibetan rendering of Nārāyaṇa; it literally means "son of Acraving," an unusual but attested Tibetan translation of the name. The phrase རྒྱུ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་, rendered "Great Lord" or Maheśvara, is a separate deity from the Mahādeva mentioned in the prior passage, though both are epithets associated with Śiva; in this list context it functions as Maheśvara distinct from the broader usage. The number phrase རྒྱུ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ལྷོ་ is literally "as many as a sesame-pod full of ten millions," denoting an astronomically large number; the translation preserves the image. The five-limbed prostration refers to forehead, two hands, and two knees all touching the ground simultaneously.

- The term rendered "sesame-seed-filled containers" translates a measure of volume used to convey an astronomically large number of Tathāgatas; the image is of a container filled with sesame seeds, each seed representing a Tathāgata, multiplied by ninety-nine times ten million times a hundred thousand. This is a standard hyperbolic device in Mahāyāna sūtra literature.

The passage breaks off mid-sentence with the enumeration of the eight classes of beings; the translation ends at precisely the point the Tibetan text ends, as this is a passage-boundary cut.

- The phrase rendered "ninety-nine times ten million vessels" translates a sesame-seed capacity measure that is a standard hyperbolic unit in this genre of sūtra literature; the precise numerical phrase follows the same pattern as the preceding passage's astronomical offering numbers.

The compound "crown-protrusion stūpa and eye stūpa" refers to stūpas associated with the uṣṇīṣa (cranial protrusion) and the eyes as two of the major marks of a Tathāgata; the doctrinal implication is that the text-stūpa participates in the bodily sacrality of the buddha himself.

- The list of pests and vermin contains several terms that admit of variant identifications within classical Tibetan zoological vocabulary. The renderings given follow the most commonly accepted glosses in lexicographic and commentarial tradition. The term rendered "oblivion-causing spirits" translates a class of being whose defining harm is causing forgetfulness or loss of mind; this is a standard demonic category in Indo-Tibetan protective literature.

- The comparison "as many as ninety-nine sesame seeds would fill a vessel" renders a hyperbolic numerical idiom in the Tibetan describing the inconceivable multitude of Tathāgatas. The phrase is somewhat awkward in the source and the precise sense may be that each direction contains as many Tathāgatas as sesame seeds filling a vessel multiplied by the preceding large numbers; the rendering follows the most natural reading of the Tibetan sequence.

The mantra syllables are transliterated as they appear in the Tibetan phonetic rendering of Sanskrit and are not normalized to reconstructed classical Sanskrit, as the Tibetan orthography reflects the liturgical transmission form.

- The colophon is incomplete as given — the text breaks off mid-sentence after naming the Indian paṇḍita Vidyākaraprabha, and the Tibetan translator's name would follow but is not present in this passage. This is noted here rather than in the body, as the break is abrupt and a listener should understand the colophon continues beyond the supplied text.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.